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TOLEDO EDISON · KENT STATE · TOLEDO

# John Pritchard Williamson, 1922–2014

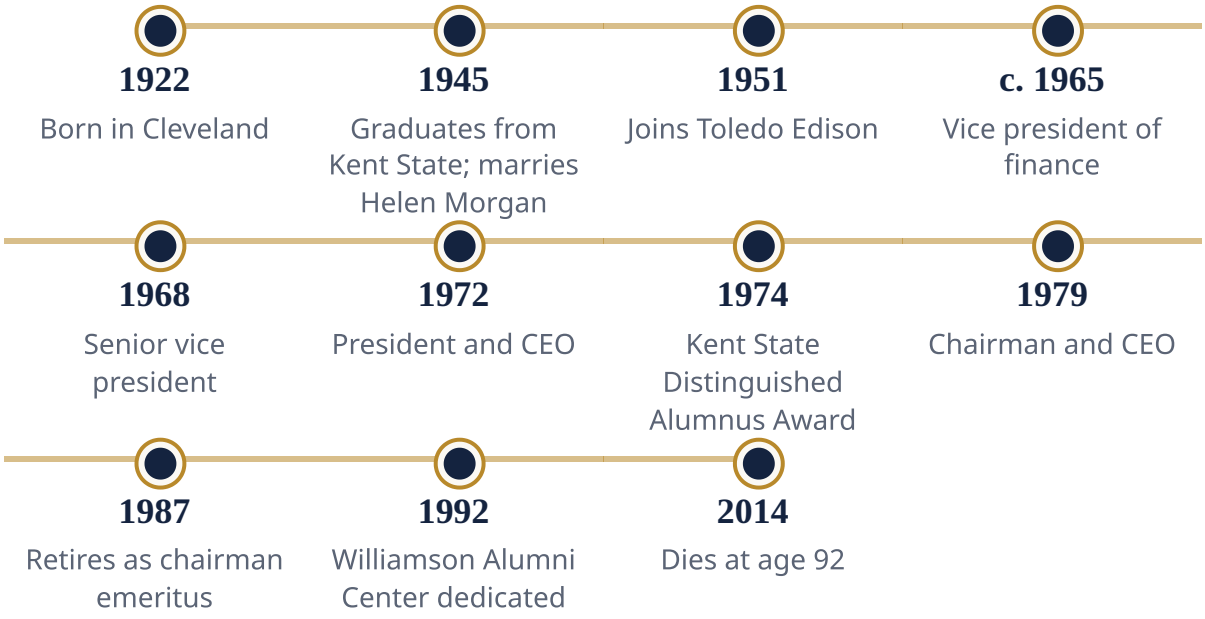
*A Cleveland-born accountant who rose to lead Toledo Edison, then spent a lifetime giving back to Toledo and to Kent State.*

> *“My mother instilled in me that everyone is obligated to leave the world a better place than when they found it.”*
>
> — JOHN WILLIAMSON[3]

## At a glance

John P. Williamson was a certified public accountant who joined Toledo Edison in 1951, led the company as president and chief executive from 1972 and as chairman and chief executive from 1979, and retired in 1987 as chairman emeritus. He was at the helm as the Davis-Besse Nuclear Power Station took shape and went into operation, and he proposed the 1980s affiliation with Cleveland Electric Illuminating Company that created Centerior Energy. Away from the office he led Toledo’s Community Chest and United Way campaigns, served on a long list of boards, and chaired the Toledo Development Committee. A 1945 Kent State graduate who worked his way through school, he won the university’s Distinguished Alumnus Award in 1974 and, with his wife, Helen, gave the lead gift for the Williamson Alumni Center.[1,2,4,5,6]

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| **BORN** | Feb. 22, 1922, Cleveland, Ohio[2,6,7,8] |
| **DIED** | Oct. 26, 2014, at Parkcliffe Community, Northwood, near Toledo, Ohio; age 92[1,2,9] |
| **CAREER** | CPA; Arthur Andersen & Company; Toledo Edison 1951–1987 (president and CEO 1972; chairman and CEO 1979; chairman emeritus 1987)[2,10,1,11] |
| **EDUCATION** | Business administration degree, Kent State University, 1945[5,12,13] |
| **HONORS** | Kent State Distinguished Alumnus Award, 1974[12]; Toledo Area Citizen of the Year[2,14]; Kentucky Colonel |
| **FAMILY** | Married Helen (Morgan) Williamson on Aug. 3, 1945[5,10]; three sons[2,5] |




# 1. At the helm of Toledo Edison

### FROM THE LEDGER TO THE CORNER OFFICE

John Williamson began his business career as a certified public accountant with Arthur Andersen & Company.[2,11,6] He and Helen spent their first six years of married life in Cleveland, then moved to Toledo in 1951 for what became his lifelong career with The Toledo

Edison Company.[5,11,3] He joined as the company's very first Director of Systems and Procedures.[2,11,10]

The climb was steady. He was named secretary and treasurer in 1962,[2,15] and by about 1965 he was vice president of finance, a title that appears beside his name on the advisory committee of Michigan State University's newly founded Institute of Public Utilities.[2,16,10] Three years later he became senior vice president.[2,10,7] As the Toledo *Blade* put it years afterward, "the certified public accountant climbed through the Edison ranks to head the utility."[1]

## PRESIDENT IN 1972, CHAIRMAN IN 1979

In 1972 Williamson succeeded John K. Davis — "the Davis in Davis-Besse," in the *Blade*'s phrase — as Toledo Edison's president, becoming the youngest person to hold that job since the utility was formed in 1921.[1,17,10] Seven years later he became chairman of the board and chief executive officer.[2,10,18] Federal filings for the Davis-Besse plant list him as president and chief executive officer of Toledo Edison in 1972 and again in 1976,[19,20] and a Federal Power Commission notice of March 1974 shows him applying for authority to serve as Toledo Edison's president, chief executive officer and a director, and as a director of the Ohio Valley Electric Corporation.[21]

## DAVIS-BESSE

On Oct. 5, 1972, a fall day of hundreds of balloons and a giant American flag flying 500 feet above the ground, Williamson stood beside Ohio Gov. John J. Gilligan at the topping-off of the 493-foot cooling tower at the Davis-Besse Nuclear Power Station near Oak Harbor. He praised the crew of 1,300 "who put brains and hands to work."[1,17]



Davis-Besse Nuclear Power Station.

The *Blade* later wrote that he "was at the helm as the nuclear power project got under way, through the startup of Davis-Besse in 1977."[1,22,20]

In 1979, after the accident at Three Mile Island, he told shareholders: "I directed, as a matter of caution, that our unit be kept off line until I could be personally satisfied that all was in order."[1]

### ONE COMPANY, TWO CITIES: THE ROAD TO CENTERIOR

In the spring of 1985, it was Williamson who raised the idea of a merger with Robert M. Ginn, chairman of Cleveland Electric Illuminating Company, over lunch in early May.[4] The plan was announced in June 1985, with Williamson, then Toledo Edison's chairman, named chairman of the new holding company.[23,4,24] Explaining the benefits, he said: "Electric rates will be lower than would otherwise be the case and customers will be better assured an adequate and reliable supply of electricity."[23] The Securities and Exchange Commission approved the affiliation in April 1986, creating Centerior Energy Corporation.[25]

Williamson announced his retirement in 1986, saying he would leave as soon as the affiliation was approved. A year later, in 1987, he retired as chairman emeritus of Toledo Edison and of Centerior Energy.[1,5]

### A VOICE FOR THE INDUSTRY

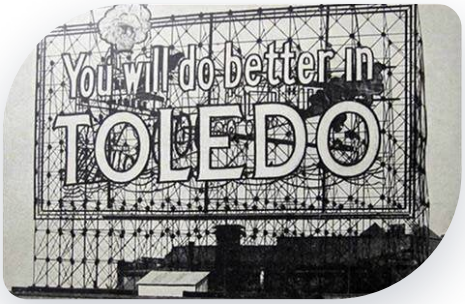
His peers asked him to lead beyond Toledo Edison. According to his obituary, he chaired the East Central Area Reliability Council,[26,10] served as president of the Ohio Electric Utility Institute,[10] sat on the executive committee of the Edison Electric Institute, chaired the Public Utilities Institute, and chaired the National Electric Security Committee.[10,2] In 1984 his industry peers selected him to serve a three-year term as chairman of the North American Electric Reliability Council, which represents the electric utilities of both the United States and Canada.[2,10,27]

## 2. A citizen of Toledo

John Williamson's obituary says he "felt a deep sense of responsibility to serve the communities of Toledo and surrounding areas."[2] The record bears that out.

### CAMPAIGNS AND CLUBS

He was chairman of the Greater Toledo Area United Way in 1971 and president of the Toledo Community Chest in 1972.[10,6,2] He was a past president of the Toledo Kiwanis Club, past president of the Toledo Area Chamber of Commerce, past chairman of the Ohio Chamber of



Toledo's "You will do better in Toledo" sign.

Commerce, and past vice president of the Toledo Council of the Boy Scouts of America.[2,6] He also served on the board of the Salvation Army and on a City of Toledo board.

## BOARDS AND TRUSTEESHIPS

He sat on the boards of the Toledo Symphony Orchestra,[3] the Toledo Museum of Art,[28] Riverside Hospital, Toledo Hospital, Toledo Trust Company, First National Bank of Toledo,[24] the American Red Cross Toledo chapter, Junior Achievement of Northwest Ohio and the Boys Club of Toledo.[2] A CPA by training, he was president of the Financial Analysts Society of Toledo in 1968–69.[14,2] In his church life he was a founding elder of Covenant United Presbyterian Church and chairman of the foundation at Epworth United Methodist Church.[2,10,24]

## MUSIC, FROM SEVERANCE HALL TO THE TOLEDO SYMPHONY

Music was a lifelong thread. As a schoolboy in Cleveland he took a field trip to Severance Hall to hear the Cleveland Symphony. "It was my first experience with classical music and it was the beginning of my lifelong enjoyment of music," he recalled.[3] In Toledo he served on the Toledo Symphony's board of trustees for nearly three decades and served as chairman.[3,2] He and Helen also arranged to establish the John P. and Helen M. Williamson Fund at the Toledo Community Foundation to support the symphony's concerts and programming for children and young people.[3]

## SHAPING THE CITY

Williamson was the first chairman of the Toledo Development Committee, created to provide a blueprint for the future development of downtown Toledo and the revitalization of the waterfront.[6,2] The Mayor and City Council gave him a recognition plaque for his leadership.[2] His obituary adds that he believed the area along Water Street should remain open so that all of Toledo's citizens could enjoy views of the Maumee River, that he was instrumental in establishing Promenade Park, and that he spearheaded the campaign to light the Anthony Wayne (Hi-Level) Bridge and the University of Toledo campus.[2]

For the Centennial of Light (1879–1979), Toledo Edison gave the University of Toledo the Toledo Edison Memorial Fountain, which stands in front of the Student Union; its plaque carries words from Williamson about the light of electricity and the light of knowledge.[9,2]

### HONORS

In 1977 Gov. James A. Rhodes appointed him to Ohio's Development Advisory Council. He was named Toledo Area Citizen of the Year.[2,14] He was also a Kentucky Colonel.

## 3. Education: ice, ink and ambition

John Williamson lost his parents at an early age and worked his way through Kent State University. He delivered blocks of ice for food refrigeration and worked in the campus print shop, where he sometimes taught other students how to run the printers.[5,2] He graduated in 1945 with a degree in business administration.[5,12,13,6] According to Prabook's profile, he later did postgraduate study at the University of Toledo and the University of Michigan in 1956.[27,11,6]

### A CAMPUS LEADER



John Williamson at Kent State.

Classmates knew him as "Johnny."[29] He served as business manager of the *Kent Stater* (now the Daily Kent Stater) in 1944, and was appointed again by university president George A. Bowman, on the recommendation of the publications committee, for the first half of 1945 — a second term in the job.[30,13,29] He was also associate editor of the *Chestnut Burr* yearbook.[31,29]

As a senior he was president of Blue Key and of the Men's Union, and was named to the campus Who's Who.[13,30,31] The Stater also lists him in Kappa Mu Kappa fraternity and Delta Sigma Pi, the national business honorary.[30]

# 4. A lifelong Golden Flash

### DISTINGUISHED ALUMNUS, 1974



John and Helen Williamson.

In 1974 Kent State gave Williamson its Distinguished Alumnus Award.[12,5,2] The Alumni Association describes its top alumni honor as one that recognizes outstanding contributions in a chosen profession and extraordinary service to the university, the community, the state, the nation and the world.[32] He and Helen became the first life members of the Kent State University Alumni Association in 1975.

### THE WILLIAMSON ALUMNI CENTER

“We had the idea to use the president’s home to attract graduates from all over,” Williamson said in a 2011 interview. “In my mind [the alumni center] created good will.”[5]



The Williamson Alumni Center, Kent State University.

The home in question was the Curtiss House, built around 1853, which Kent State bought in 1942 and which housed the university’s presidents until 1988, when it was offered to alumni relations.[33,5,34] John and Helen gave the lead gift for its renovation; private gifts of $1.6 million funded the work and an addition, and Alumni Association staff moved in during January 1990.[33,5] The addition was built from fall 1991 to summer 1992, and the Williamson Alumni Center was dedicated on Oct. 10, 1992.[33,35,5] The Alumni Association has since relocated, but the Williamson House still serves the Kent State community.[5]

*Who’s Who in America* (1992–93 edition) lists Williamson as the recipient of a Kent State University medallion in 1992.[14] The couple’s planned giving through the Toledo Community Foundation includes future funds to support the Williamson Alumni Center and a scholarship for Kent State students.[3]

## 5. Retirement: horses, horizons and home



John Williamson on horseback.

Retirement suited John Williamson. He and Helen kept homes in Rio Verde, Arizona, and Perrysburg, Ohio, and he enjoyed horseback riding. They traveled the world — Europe, Africa, the Americas and Asia — and he simply enjoyed life.

In 1996 he was qualified to serve as a Stephen Minister at Rio Verde Community Church, a quiet continuation of a lifetime of service.

## 6. Family and farewell

### ROOTS

John Pritchard Williamson was born on Feb. 22, 1922, in Cleveland, Ohio, to John and Jane (Pritchard) Williamson.[2,6,10] He lost his parents at an early age.[5,2] He was preceded in death by his brother, Ivor Williamson, and his sister, Betty Irwin.[2]

### HELEN

His favorite Kent State memory, he said in a 2011 interview, was meeting Helen Morgan, a member of Tri Sigma.[5] The print shop played a part: when Helen's sister came in for a lesson, he asked her on a date.[5] "We got engaged in college and were married on Aug. 3, 1945."[5,10] Helen, who majored in home economics, stayed home to care for their three sons and became an active volunteer.[5] Their marriage lasted 69 years.[2] Helen died on Aug. 5, 2019.[5,36]

### FAREWELL

John Williamson died peacefully on Oct. 26, 2014, at Parkcliffe Community in Northwood, at the age of 92.[1,2,9] A memorial service was planned for Nov. 1, 2014, at Swan Creek Retirement Village, with a private interment at Joy Cemetery in Ottawa Hills.[2,8]



John and Helen Williamson. Photo by Bob Christy ’95, Kent State University Alumni Association.

John was survived by his wife of 69 years, Helen, who died Aug. 5, 2019.[2,5,36] His obituary also named his sons, John M. (Karol) Williamson, James R. Williamson and Wayne A. (Kathy) Williamson; his grandson, John R. Williamson, and great-grandson, John D. Williamson; and family members Christopher (Kim) Seitz, Lisa (Greg) Bowling, Laura (Tom) Baird and Jamison (Amanda) Adams.[2]

Kent State’s own tribute said it plainly: John and Helen “will always be remembered for their dedication to Kent State and for creating a home for Golden Flash alumni.”[5]

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## PHOTO CREDITS

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Last updated October 27, 2026